From: **Rob Reuss** robreuss@mac.com
Subject: Letter from the producer
Date: February 9, 2026 at 9:35 AM
To: Marc Weiss mweiss@weblab.org

Hey Marc,

I had ChatGPT work on your draft and gave it all the content from the discussion - you can see my prompt and other notes from ChatGPT in the link below, and I've pasted the result in as well.

I made a couple of attempts to create an image to accompany the letter without an outstanding result. Probably needs to be more abstract.

Rob

FROM CHATGPT:

Below is a revised and expanded **"Letter from the Producer"** that aims to do three things at once:

1. situate the archive historically (technically, culturally, politically),
2. prepare the reader for the tone and texture of what they're about to encounter, and
3. frame the forum not as a curiosity or artifact, but as an early, serious experiment in public meaning-making online.

I've kept your voice and first-person authority, but tightened the narrative arc, clarified what was genuinely new in 1995–96, and foregrounded the Vietnam context as a *continuing* moral and emotional reckoning rather than a closed chapter. I've also gently prepared modern readers—accustomed to social media—for the differences they will notice: slowness, earnestness, vulnerability, disagreement without spectacle.

Letter from the Producer

In the early months of 1996, I found myself standing at the edge of something new, without fully realizing how rare that moment was.

As Executive Producer of POV, I had been experimenting for several years with ways the emerging internet might extend the life of the films we broadcast. Those early efforts were tentative and, by today's standards, rudimentary. In 1995—after the first widely accessible web browsers appeared—we created what was likely the first website for a public television series, and possibly one of the first television-related websites of any kind. It offered background material on each film: context, production notes, links. Useful, perhaps, but static. Once read, there was little reason to return.

That changed dramatically in the fall of 1995.

When POV aired *Leona's Sister Gerri*, a devastating film about Gerri Santoro, who died in 1964 after a botched illegal abortion, we invited viewers to share their own experiences with unwanted pregnancy. Within twenty-four hours, more than 1,100 responses arrived. What struck us was not their political alignment, but their humanity. These were not arguments or slogans. They were first-person accounts—stories of fear, responsibility, love, loss, values, and consequence. People were not debating an issue; they were bearing witness to their lives.

It was a revelation. For the first time, I grasped that the internet might support something

It was a revelation. For the first time, I grasped that the internet might support something fundamentally different from broadcast media's familiar "one-to-many" model. What if, instead of a single voice speaking outward, we created a space where people could read one another, respond, and add their own perspectives—a genuinely "many-to-many" exchange? What kinds of conversations might emerge if the technology made listening as central as speaking?

With that question in mind, we set out in early 1996 to conduct a series of experiments: interactive websites linked to three POV films broadcast that season. One film, in particular, seemed uniquely suited to this approach—Frieda Lee Mock's extraordinary documentary on Maya Lin, the designer of the Vietnam Veterans Memorial in Washington, D.C.

The film traces Lin's winning design, the intense resistance it provoked, her steadfast defense of her vision, and the profound emotional power the Memorial has come to hold for people across political, generational, and cultural divides. The Wall, as it is commonly known, is both spare and overwhelming—a place of grief, remembrance, reckoning, and, for many, healing.

For me, the project was deeply personal. I came of age during the Vietnam War, and like so many others, my life was shaped by it in ways both obvious and subtle: my work, my relationships, my moral framework, my understanding of authority and dissent. Whether one fought in the war, protested it, lost someone, fled its aftermath as a refugee, or lived through it from a distance, Vietnam left few untouched.

If the Vietnam Veterans Memorial offered a physical space for reflection and healing, I wondered whether it might be possible to create a digital one.

The website that emerged had two core elements: **stories** and **dialogues**.

The stories were not intended to be chronicles of events so much as reflections on meaning—accounts of how experiences during the Vietnam era shaped who people later became. We seeded the site with stories collected in advance of the broadcast and invited visitors to contribute their own. Some were highlighted; all were preserved as part of a growing, searchable archive.

The greater experiment, however, was the dialogue space.

We created a small number of initial topics and allowed anyone visiting the site to introduce new ones. Within each topic, participants could post responses and reply to one another. The exchange was asynchronous: people might write one day, return days or weeks later, and find that others had read their words, reflected on them, and answered in turn.

What followed exceeded anything I had anticipated.

Over time, the dialogue developed a momentum of its own, continuing for nearly a year and eventually encompassing hundreds of topics and thousands of individual contributions. Participants disagreed—sometimes sharply—but they also listened, questioned, reconsidered, and, not infrequently, expressed gratitude for having been heard. Veterans and protesters, family members, immigrants, nurses, students, and observers encountered one another not as abstractions, but as people speaking from lived experience.

Reading through these exchanges now, decades later, what stands out is their tone: the seriousness with which participants approached one another, the patience of the medium, the absence of performative outrage, and the willingness—often tentative, sometimes courageous—to speak vulnerably in public. This was not a space designed for virality or persuasion. It was a space shaped, imperfectly but earnestly, for reflection and exchange.

For me, the project offered a glimpse of what the internet *might* become: a tool for building community, bridging difference, deepening understanding, and expanding perspective. Inspired by this experience, I eventually stepped away from my role at POV and founded Web Lab, a nonprofit organization dedicated to exploring the web's civic and cultural potential.

This archive preserves that experiment—not as nostalgia, but as evidence. It captures a moment when the internet was still new enough that its social forms were unsettled, when participants were inventing norms in real time, and when a national conversation about Vietnam—long suppressed, fragmented, or polarized—found an unexpected new venue.

As you explore these discussions, I invite you to read slowly. Listen for what is said plainly, and for what is being worked out in real time. What you will find here is not consensus, but encounter—and a record of people trying, with the tools they had, to understand one another across the long shadow of history.

If you'd like, I can also:

- produce a **short curator's note** for contemporary readers explaining how this differs from modern social media,
- draft a **content advisory / reading guide**, or
- help you decide how much editorial framing is appropriate versus letting the archive "speak for itself."

Rob